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A Reflection on the "Gateway to Himalayan Art"

In the Hindu traditions, the notion of Karma is an integral concept to the structure of religious practice and belief. The exhibit description titled "MERIT" states "Tied closely to the concept of karma, merit is an investment in the future that can bring about results in this lifetime or future ones. Specifically, in Himalayan culture, it is believed that religious merit can be obtained through the commissioning of artwork, the making of it, viewing it, or praying to the deity depicted. In cases when the art pieces are "wheels of life" – spinning them can attain good karma and merit as well as walking repeatedly around a stupa, at times coupled with the recantation of a mantra ("Merit", 2024). To me it is evident why individuals would take the time to make such artwork as it would have a variety of theoretical benefits, serving more than just the creator or viewer alone. Additionally, in the description of "Secular Aims" we see that the commissioning of art and religious rituals do not contradict each other and are not "antithetical" because the production and consumption of the art still promotes "good health, long life, and material support" and can serve all people regardless of faith ("Secular Aims", 2024). Further in this reflection I will delve into the symbolism of wheels of life, stupas, and other painted and sculpted artworks. However, I'd first like to reflect upon the article "Death, the Bardo, and Rebirth in Tibetan Buddhism" by Dzigar Kongtrul Rinpoche published by the Rubin Museum of Art.

In “Death, the Bardo, and Rebirth in Tibetan Buddhism,” Rinpoche discusses that upon death it takes some time for a soul to come to terms with the fact that its physical body has died. Thus, "Tremendous grief arises, especially if due to strong attachments in your previous life, you didn’t spend time contemplating and accepting impermanence and death" (Rinpoche, Rubin Museum of Art). From what I’ve learned in this course, other religion courses, as well as in “what is the good life”, I believe that contemplating death and impermanence is necessary to live a meaningful life. They motivate us to do things that we actively consider “worth it". Additionally, I am reminded of Buddhist traditions discussed in “Death and Dying in World Religions” by Bregman. It details that “The Pure Self is not constructed. It is neither born nor does it die. It is, according to Samkhya philosophy, pure consciousness… Samkhya’s method entails the primacy of knowledge as an instrumental means to enlightenment, the discovery of the profound innermost self, by practicing meditative disciplines” (p 102). These references portray that self-discovery through meditation, acceptance, inquiry, and learning is necessary for not only a fulfilling life but for a fulfilling afterlife as it aids in determining where the soul is drawn to, to then be reborn.

Further elaborating on the “in-between” state or “the Bardo”, Rinpoche goes on to say that “When you observe the love and care your relatives once had for you fade, you feel immensely alienated and alone.” To me it is evident that this is likely an essential part of motivating people to create shrines and traditions about remembering their ancestors, thus providing a mechanism through which grief can be channeled. The descriptions present that this is exemplified through the construction of shrine cabinets known as dharma displays (chosham) with the aim of presenting sacred items in a private place of worship. Traditionally, the Buddha’s teachings and Tibetan books are neatly wrapped and placed at the top and the bottom contains items unique to

the families' as it stemmed from their place in history, geographical location, and family ties. The image to the right depicts a chosham with seven figures unique to this specific family and their rituals and beliefs.

On another note, Rinpoche discusses that conflict can arise amongst the family of the deceased, over the resources that had been acquired with the deceased's "own blood, sweat, and tears," causing incredible pain to the departed. From my perspective, this notion would be a good motivator for people to remain calm during a time of mourning and to engage in activities that do not involve conflict and instead support each other during their time of grief. The catalyst stemming from the belief that their actions have some effect on their loved ones. The last reflection I have on Rinpoche's work is a comment on the fact that "dynamics may start before conception and influence the biological gender of the child," with Tibetan traditionalism seeing one's gender to be formed upon the entrance of semen into the mother's womb. Thus, leading the mind to develop in an ultimate manner where a gender identity is instilled from the day of conception (Rinpoche, Rubin Museum of Art). Relating this to modern society and concerns - I wonder how the Tibetan people would feel about the concept of gender fluidity and being transgender? In my mind, personal gender identity differences seem to directly oppose the position that gender is formed either right before conception or at its very beginning.

Figure 1 Shrine Cabinet (chosham). Tibet, second half of 20th century. Wood, mineral pigments. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Kingdoms Unlimited. SC202121a-cc

In the remainder of this reflection, I will use images presented in the exhibition to analyze general symbolism and properties of Tibetan scroll paintings in pieces that stood out to me ("Symbols", 2024) and ("Composition and Structure", 2024). I'd like to first go back to the "wheel of life" (or wheel of existence), mentioned earlier. This painting appears to be instructional in nature, depicting a story that shows how one can escape samsara just as the Buddha did. There are skulls present at the top of this wheel, creating a foreboding tone in addition to the depiction of the Lord of Death. The wheel aims to show how one can escape samsara by navigating the various realms of the afterlife and influencing where one ends up. Thus, I believe the juxtaposition provides a convincing and stirring image portraying deaths' grip, implanting a passion for change in the viewer – directly showing why creating a religious work of art can bring good karma as one is creating an opportunity for others to contemplate and better their lives. The depiction of Buddha at the top left provides a powerful image of another option than the various realms of the afterlife - to escape the cycle by learning the dharma.

Figure 3 Wheel of Existence. Tibet; 18th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of the Shelley & Donald Rubin Foundation. F1997.40.10 (HAR 591)

Figure 2Medical Painting of Minor Connecting Blood Vessels or Capillaries, Illustration to the Medical Treatise. The Blue Beryl, Chapter 4. Tibet; 18th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Shelley and Donald Rubin. C2006.66.570 (HAR 1054)

One of my favorite works of art – although not a strictly religious painting - was a medical painting of the blood vessels. From what I observed and read, it seems that it was meant to lead to and inspire healing.

In the process of doing so, it depicts a whole human who is then reduced to inner organs and then a skull and a skeleton. Additionally, the positioning of the drawn being reminds me of the archer/hunting stance and the hands seems to mimic the positioning of hands in religious works which aim to portray a sense of protection. Together, the symbolism of positioning and creating a sense that the physician knows how the body works and can portray that to their patients through these drawings, likely putting them at ease. In this instance, I believe the artist would indeed gain merit from the making of this work.

Figure 4 Sitatapatra. Tibet; dated 1864. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of the Shelley & Donald Rubin Foundation. F1996.18.1 (HAR 468)

Returning to the concept of merit, the painting "Sitatapatra" was commissioned by a loving husband from Tibet for his late wife, with the intent of it bringing her a better rebirth in her next life ("Sitatapatra", Rubin Museum of Art). The central largest figure seems to represent a Female Deity as the face is oval (female depiction) and she has four other faces, portraying many abilities. She is likely not a Tantric deity as she isn't holding a skull cup or a curved knife. At the bottom of the painting there are three figures which all seem to be wrathful deities, likely ones who served as obstacles as she appears to be stomping them out. Additionally, while she isn't holding a tantric staff, she is holding a white parasol that represents benevolence, again portraying her goodness. One of the figures on the top right appears to be depicting the hand gestures of prayer or reverence. Overall, all these factors create an inspiring and hopeful image that, the woman who died will have a successful journey through the afterlife.

The last painted work which I'd like to analyze is the "Refuge Field with Machik Labdron"

(1055-1153). The main goal of a refuge field is portraying all the deities and teachers in a tradition in one place so its legitimacy can be traced. The central figure is a female deity with a halo, in the dancing position on top of the Lotus throne. There are figures directly to the left and right of her, indicating that they are deities in the entourage. While this is a more complex painting as it depicts the traditions' lineage, the root deity can still be identified as the one in the middle at the highest point and this is from whom all the original traditions and teachings come from. Below the root deity, and to the left and right of it, are the teachers that were instrumental in passing the teaching down to the disciples. The hand gestures of most of them involves either their right hand portraying a "granting wishes and blessings" stance and others have their hand in the position that implies protection and encourages one "not to fear". In this case the large groups are present to portray the involvement of everyone in the lineage. At the bottom are all the protectors of the lineage, the deities who are wrathful, as depicted by their flaming heir and bulging eyes. Wholistically, this is not only a beautiful depiction of the religious tradition, but also it is an effective method of seeing how many individuals have been involved in the support of the traditions and provides an idea of how long the traditions have been active for, as the older they are, the more figures will be present.

Figure 5 Refuge Field with Machik Labdron (1055-1153). Tibet; early 20th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Shelley and Donald Rubin. C2006.66.11 (HAR 223)

To conclude and lightly touch on Stupas, during a lecture, we learned about them. This led them to stand out to me upon my time at the Harn museum, immediately drawing me in to take a

picture and appreciate its importance. It's nice to actively see how this course is leading me to better appreciate art, not only religions. I already go to the Harn on a regular basis – fascinated by the cultural exhibits as well as the different types of art. I often do my readings there and while I've never taken an art appreciation course, this experience makes me want to learn more about it and investigate the resources available to do so. As I am soon graduating, this course is likely the last time I will learn about such fascinating topics in an academic setting. I am excited and feel equipped, to use the knowledge I've acquired to ask numerous meaningful questions. However, it is still a bittersweet transition, but as I've learned with all these courses and especially this one, impermanence is the one permanent thing, and embracing it is key to a fulfilling life.

Figure 6 Stupa. Tibet; 14th century. Copper alloy. Rubin Museum of Art. C2003.12.2 (HAR 65213).

Works Cited

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Figure 7. Shrine Cabinet (chosham). Tibet, second half of 20th century. Wood, mineral pigments. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Kingdoms Unlimited. SC202121a-cc.

Figure 8. Wheel of Existence. Tibet; 18th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of the Shelley & Donald Rubin Foundation. F1997.40.10 (HAR 591).

Figure 9. Medical Painting of Minor Connecting Blood Vessels or Capillaries, Illustration to the Medical Treatise. The Blue Beryl, Chapter 4. Tibet; 18th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Shelley and Donald Rubin. C2006.66.570 (HAR 1054).

Figure 10. Sitatapatra. Tibet; dated 1864. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of the Shelley & Donald Rubin Foundation. F1996.18.1 (HAR 468).

Figure 11. Refuge Field with Machik Labdron (1055-1153). Tibet; early 20th century. Pigments on cloth. Rubin Museum of Art. Gift of Shelley and Donald Rubin. C2006.66.11 (HAR 223).

Figure 12. Stupa. Tibet; 14th century. Copper alloy. Rubin Museum of Art. C2003.12.2 (HAR 65213).

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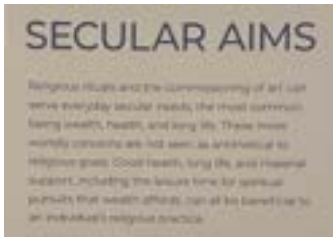

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SYMBOLS
POSTURES
GESTURES
IMPLEMENTS